THEATRE MANAGEMENT

Budgeting, Marketing and Front of House

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

Where the money goes, how to price a ticket, how to fill a house without giving it away, and what the audience meets at the door.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- the budget
- ticket pricing
- marketing
- box office
- front of house

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The budget is a list of decisions

Split the budget into what happens before rehearsals (rights, design, materials), what happens during (venue, fees, transport, food, publicity) and what happens after (strike, storage, debts). Add a contingency line of ten per cent and protect it.

Rights are the item student companies forget. A published play needs a licence for performance, and the licence usually specifies the fee, the number of performances and the credit line. Applying for rights takes weeks; start before the season is announced.

Pricing

Price by what the market will bear and by what the production costs, then choose one discount: students, groups, or previews. Too many price categories confuse the box office and slow the queue.

Free tickets are a legitimate choice for a campus production, but they hide the real audience size. Count attendance even when the tickets are free; the number is the only evidence you will have when you ask for funding next year.

Marketing that works locally

For a campus or community production, the best marketing is a person: a company member talking to a class, a department, a church group, a hostel. Posters and social media are reminders, not recruitment.

Make one image and one sentence, and use them everywhere. A poster with six fonts and a paragraph of synopsis is a poster nobody reads. Say what the play is, when it is, where it is, and what it costs, in that order.

Front of house

The audience's evening begins in the queue. Signage, a warm greeting, a place to leave bags, a programme, a working toilet, water, and a clear announcement of the running time and the interval will do more for the reputation of the company than any review.

Train the ushers on three things: where people sit, what to do if someone is ill or disruptive, and how to hold the door until the interval. Front of house is safety with a smile.

The break-even calculation

Break-even is the number of tickets you must sell before the production stops losing money: total costs divided by the average ticket price. If the budget is 600,000 naira and the average ticket is 2,000, you need 300 sales. If the hall holds 250, you cannot break even in one night, and the season needs either a higher price, a sponsor, or a smaller budget.

Do the calculation before the season is announced, not after the first week of sales. It tells you how many nights you need, whether a free student matinee is affordable, and how much of the budget must come from sponsorship. It also tells you the moment to cut a line item rather than hope.

Track sales daily and compare with the break-even line. A production that is behind on Tuesday can still be saved by a school booking; one that discovers the gap on Friday cannot. The manager's job is to see the number early enough to act on it.

Sponsorship without humiliation

A sponsor buys an audience, a reputation or a photograph. Write one page that says what the audience is, what the sponsor's name will appear on, and what the money will pay for. Ask for a specific sum for a specific line item; "support the arts" is not a request.

Deliver what you promised, in writing, with photographs, and thank the sponsor publicly. The second ask is always easier than the first, and the department's reputation for delivering is worth more than any single cheque.

Exercises

1. Build a budget for a three-night run in a 250-seat hall, with a contingency line and a break-even calculation.
2. Write the one-sentence description and the poster copy for a production you have worked on.
3. Design a front-of-house plan: staffing, signage, queue, interval and evacuation.

Where to read more

Brander Matthews, A Book About the Theater (1916)

Colley Cibber, An Apology for the Life of Mr. Colley Cibber (1740)

Stephen Langley, Theatre Management and Production in America (1990)

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